

Cisco Secure Workload - ACSC Essential Eight Compliance Report

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Customer-Facing Compliance Report

Framework: Australian Cyber Security Centre (ACSC) Essential Eight Maturity Model

Primary audience: Australian Commonwealth, state, and territory government agencies and the broader Australian public and private sector using Essential Eight as the baseline maturity reference.

CSW positioning: Patch prioritisation using CVE + reachability, administrative-path restriction at the workload-to-workload layer, and supporting evidence for application control through observed process telemetry.

Framework Version Note

References the Essential Eight Maturity Model as published by ACSC. The model uses three Maturity Levels (ML1, ML2, ML3). The eight mitigation strategies are: Application Control, Patch Applications, Configure Microsoft Office Macro Settings, User Application Hardening, Restrict Administrative Privileges, Patch Operating Systems, Multi-Factor Authentication, Regular Backups. CSW only supports a subset of these; the others are out of scope. Validate maturity-level requirements against the current ACSC publication.

CSW UI Navigation Note

Cisco does not yet publish framework-specific CSW UI navigation for this standard; framework-specific navigation is on the product roadmap. This report references CSW *capabilities* and the *evidence artifacts* they produce. The reference design (CSW-Essential-Eight-Technical-Reference design.md) in this folder contains the deeper engineering detail.

How to read the Coverage column

Every report in this set uses the same three coverage words. Coverage describes **what evidence CSW produces** for a topic — it never means the control is passed.

Direct — Secure Workload produces the primary evidence artifact for that topic (segmentation, policy, flow/process telemetry, inventory, vulnerability + reachability, forensic reconstruction). Direct is still evidence, not an attestation.

Supporting — Secure Workload contributes an input that feeds or complements another control, tool, or process (e.g. detection input only, reconciled against an external register, one log source among several).

Evidence Required — Secure Workload has no record for this topic. The customer supplies the contract, the analysis, or the HR / physical-security evidence from another control.

The Coverage ratings in the topic map below are machine-derived from each row's wording and are flagged for SE review before customer use.

Executive Summary

Cisco Secure Workload (CSW) supports a defined subset of this framework. The strongest customer story is not that CSW “certifies” compliance; it is that CSW turns workload communication and inventory into evidence that the customer, the customer’s compliance team, and the customer’s assessor can review. This report describes which framework topics CSW supports, which it does not, what evidence artifacts CSW produces, and how often the customer should collect them. CSW does **not** replace the customer’s governance, policy, or assessor judgement, and this report is **not** a control attestation.

Suggested CSW Scope Pattern

Essential-Eight

- Critical-Applications
- Admin-Paths (Jump-Hosts, Admin-Workstations)
- Patch-Priority-Targets
- Application-Control-Support

This scope pattern should be validated with the customer’s architecture, application owners, compliance team, and assessor before it is used for formal evidence.

In Scope for CSW Evidence

- E2 / E6 - Patch Applications and Patch Operating Systems (reachability-weighted prioritisation)
- E5 - Restrict Administrative Privileges (workload-to-workload admin path restriction)
- E1 - Application Control (supporting evidence via observed process telemetry; CSW does not enforce application control)

Out of Scope (Must Be Evidenced by Other Controls / Tools / Processes)

- E3 - Configure Microsoft Office Macro Settings (endpoint configuration)
- E4 - User Application Hardening (endpoint configuration)
- E7 - Multi-Factor Authentication (identity layer)
- E8 - Regular Backups (backup / recovery)
- Essential Eight maturity-level scoring decisions

Framework Topic → CSW Capability Map

Framework topic	Coverage	CSW capability	Evidence artifact
E2 - Patch Applications (prioritisation)	Direct	Reachability-weighted CVE on application workloads	Prioritised remediation list with compensating-control register
E6 - Patch Operating Systems (prioritisation)	Direct	Reachability-weighted CVE on OS layer	Prioritised remediation list
E5 - Restrict Administrative Privileges (workload layer)	Direct	Policy workspace + admin-path allowlist	Workspace snapshot showing admin-path restrictions + jump-host flow report
E1 - Application Control (supporting)	Supporting	Observed process telemetry	Process inventory and unexpected-process anomalies as input to application control content
Maturity-level evidence (across the above)	Direct	Periodic evidence pack	Quarterly evidence bundle covering the three CSW-supported strategies

Evidence Collection Approach

The table below describes per-topic evidence collection - what to collect, the CSW source area, and a suggested cadence. The cadence should be tuned to the customer's audit cycle, regulatory cadence, and risk appetite.

Topic	What to collect	CSW source	Suggested cadence
Critical workload inventory	Workloads in scope of Essential Eight uplift	Inventory + scope membership export	Monthly
Patch prioritisation	CVE list weighted by reach and exploitability	Vulnerability report scoped to Essential-Eight	Monthly
Admin path restriction	Jump-host and admin-workstation flow telemetry	Flow search on Admin-Paths + policy workspace export	Continuous; reviewed monthly
Application control input	Observed process telemetry on critical workloads	Process inventory and anomaly report	Quarterly

POV / Workshop Approach

1. Confirm the framework version and assessment cycle with the customer's compliance team.
2. Select one business service, regulated boundary, or critical workload group to start with; do not attempt to instrument the entire estate in the POV.
3. Validate workload coverage and install sensors or configure supported connectors. Document the cannot-instrument register; this is itself evidence.
4. Apply labels for application, environment, owner, data class, criticality, compliance scope, and any framework-specific tags (e.g. `tenant`, `prototype`, `isa_level`, `npi`, `cui`, `ephi`).
5. Observe flows over a representative business window. Minimum two weeks; longer if the customer has month-end, quarterly, or seasonal cycles relevant to the scope.
6. Use ADM to generate a candidate policy. Review with the application owner. Run in Simulation mode for at least two weeks before any enforcement.
7. Package inventory, scope, flows, policy, exceptions, and known gaps as the evidence output. Cross-reference this report's evidence collection table with the customer's existing audit work-papers.

Boundaries and Complementary Controls

CSW does not enforce application control on endpoints, harden user applications, configure Office macro settings, enforce MFA, perform backups, or replace ACSC maturity-level assessment ownership.

Assessor / Auditor Caveat

CSW provides technical evidence inputs. The customer's qualified assessor, auditor, certifying body, or regulator determines compliance status. Validate all framework-topic mappings, control IDs, paragraph references, and section numbers in this report against the current official framework text. If the customer is being assessed against a version other than the one referenced in the framework version note above, revalidate before use.

Disclaimer

This report is for informational and planning purposes. It is not legal, regulatory, audit, or certification advice. Validate all mappings against the current official framework text, the customer's environment, and qualified compliance, legal, and audit professionals.